

THE MORNING BRIEFING

MARCUS JOHNSON'S SUNDAY PAPER — POLITICS, LAW, AND THE WEEK'S IDEAS

THE WEEK'S LEAD STORY

The Iran War Is Now the Midterm War

Oil above \$100, a defense secretary facing impeachment articles, the Supreme Court blocking a president's ballot rules, and a vice president who let slip what the White House won't say out loud: the war and the election have become the same story.

U.S. POLITICS

Midterms Open Under the Shadow of an Active War

Early in-person voting for the November 3 midterms began this week — Virginia first, with Idaho, Minnesota, and South Dakota following — as control of both chambers of Congress goes on the ballot against the backdrop of a live U.S.-Iran war, a cost-of-living squeeze, and gas prices that have not calmed since the Strait of Hormuz strikes began. Republicans hold narrow majorities in both chambers, and the historical pattern — the president's party loses ground in midterms — is working against them even before the war is factored in.

Congress avoided a fall shutdown fight by extending funding at current levels through December 11, punting the real appropriations battle until after voters have spoken; the House passed the stopgap 370-48, a rare bipartisan margin that reflects how little either party wants a shutdown story competing with the war for headlines this fall.

President Trump escalated his conflict with the press this week, announcing he had banned CNN, MS NOW, and Politico from the White House over what he called “FAKE NEWS” coverage — a move press-freedom groups immediately called a First Amendment violation, and one that lands in the same week the Supreme Court was reining in his election-related executive authority (see Judiciary).

READ

A White House banning three outlets and a president who spent March trying to rewrite how mail ballots get delivered are not separate stories — both are attempts to shape the information and mechanics of an election the president's party is expected to lose ground in. The pattern is defensive, not confident.

NPR · npr.org/2026/09/16NBC News · nbcnews.com/politics/2026-electionWashington Post · washingtonpost.com/politics/2026/09/18

Massie Forces an Impeachment Reckoning on Hegseth — Then the House Runs Out the Clock

Kentucky Republican Thomas Massie filed eight articles of impeachment against Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, accusing him of prosecuting the Iran war in violation of the War Powers Resolution, retaliating against Senator Mark Kelly for protected speech, and unlawfully directing the operation that captured Venezuela's Nicolás Maduro in January. House leadership responded by sending members home a day early for the cycle's final pre-election recess, ensuring no floor vote happens until members return November 9 — safely after Election Day.

That a sitting member of the president's own party filed the articles, and that leadership's response was procedural avoidance rather than a fight, says as much about internal GOP anxiety over the war's legal footing as anything Democrats have said about it this year.

NBC News · nbcnews.com/politics/congress/2026/09/16CNN · cnn.com/2026/09/16/politics/house-early-recess-hegseth-impeachment

Vance's “Another Chance” Slip

Vice President JD Vance, campaigning on the “All In” podcast, asked voters to “give us another chance” before catching himself and revising it to “another couple of years” — a phrasing that concedes exactly the vulnerability Trump's own messaging has avoided naming directly. Vance struggled in the same appearance to defend the administration's record on Iran and inflation, then headed to Iowa Friday to headline a midterm rally in Council Bluffs, his second Iowa trip this year.

Rolling Stone · rollingstone.com/politics/politics-news/2026/09/17

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

The Court Blocks Trump's Mail-Ballot Order — Again

In a brief, unsigned Monday-night ruling, the Supreme Court kept in place a lower court's freeze on the administration's plan to have the Postal Service block delivery of mail ballots to voters not on a state-presubmitted list, writing that “the Government is unlikely to succeed on the merits.” The order traces to a March executive directive and has bounced between district

courts, an August emergency stay in the administration's favor, and now this denial — the practical effect is that voters face no new mail-voting hurdles for November.

The underlying constitutional question is not close on paper: Article I, Section 4 gives election administration to the states, with a backstop role for Congress, not the presidency. The fact that this case reached the Court at all, twice, in an election year is itself the story.

Votebeat · votebeat.org/national/2026/09/15
SCOTUSblog · scotusblog.com/2026/09

NRCC v. Brown: A Last-Minute Stay on Campaign Ad Rates

On September 4 — the same day the “lowest unit charge” window opened for the midterms — the Court stayed a Fourth Circuit ruling that had struck down an FCC notice governing the discount rates broadcasters must offer candidates. The case turns on a narrow procedural question (whether a court can hear a challenge to an FCC notice while the FCC's own review of that notice is still

pending), but the practical stakes are which candidates get cheap airtime heading into November. Justice Jackson dissented.

Law.Cornell.edu / **SCOTUSblog** · scotusblog.com/cases/national-republican-congressional-committee-v-brown

Missouri's Map Fight Heads Back to Washington

The Missouri Supreme Court unanimously blocked the Trump-backed, GOP-drawn congressional map from use in November and ordered a statewide referendum, ruling that the 2020-census map remains in force until voters decide Proposition A on November 3. Missouri Attorney General Catherine Hanaway is appealing to the U.S. Supreme Court, arguing the ruling “disenfranchises” voters by denying them the new map — an inversion of the usual disenfranchisement argument worth noting on its own terms.

Missouri Independent · missouriindependent.com/2026/09/03
NBC News · nbcnews.com/politics/2026-election

governorate to connect two planned settlements. Peace Now calls it the first time since the Oslo Accords that seizure orders in Area A have been issued explicitly for settler benefit rather than under a security rationale. Israel has also advanced its E1 settlement corridor, which would functionally sever the West Bank's north from its south.

READ

“Security zone” and “self-defense” are the standard official vocabulary for actions like this; Peace Now's own characterization — seizure orders issued openly for settler benefit, not security — is the more precise read, and it comes from an Israeli organization, not a hostile outside one.

Amnesty International · amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2026/09
Al Jazeera · aljazeera.com/features/2026/2/9

Israel's Own Election Turns Into a Disqualification Fight

Ahead of the October 27 Knesset election, the far-right Otzma Yehudit party and the left-wing Democrats party filed dueling petitions with Israel's Central Elections Committee to bar each other from running — Otzma citing Democrats leader Yair Golan's remarks calling West Bank settlers “subhuman” and Haredim a “parasitic population,” the Democrats citing Otzma's record on incitement. Likud separately moved to disqualify an Arab party. Polling shows both major blocs still short of the 61 seats needed to govern.

Times of Israel · timesofisrael.com/liveblog-september-14-2026
Haaretz · haaretz.com/israel-news/elections/2026-09-14

Iran Sets Terms, Oil Stays Above \$100

Iran's security chief Mohsen Rezaei relayed conditions to Qatari and Pakistani mediators for talks with Washington: an end to the war on all fronts, unfreezing Iranian funds, and lifting the U.S. naval blockade. Trump says the war will end “very soon” — and, notably, predicts that will happen after the midterms, while accusing Tehran of stalling to complicate the U.S. election. Oil crossed \$100 a barrel this week for the first time since July after the U.S. and Iran traded fresh strikes near the Strait of Hormuz, and Iran-

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Washington Approves 40,000 More Bombs for Israel, Even as Gaza's “Ceasefire” Body Count Climbs

The Trump administration is moving ahead with a \$2.8 billion munitions package for Israel — 20,000 Mk84 and 20,000 BLU-117 2,000-pound bombs plus bunker-penetrating warheads — funded through Foreign Military Financing, meaning U.S. taxpayers underwrite Israel's purchase of U.S.-made weapons. It is the latest in a string of sales this year that have bypassed the normal congressional review window, following a \$6.67 billion package in January and a \$3 billion sale last year that included similar bombs the Biden administration once paused over mass-casualty concerns in Gaza.

The sale lands the same week reporting confirmed at least 1,381 Palestinians have been killed in Gaza since the October 2025 ceasefire was announced, including 21 — 12 of them children — in a building collapse this week that the IDF says it did not cause, and a strike on a motorcycle in Sheikh Radwan that killed one and wounded a child.

ANALYSIS

Treat this the way you'd treat a major arms package to any rival power's client: follow the money and the timing. Financing the sale through FMF means the political cost of a “new” weapons deal is hidden inside foreign-aid accounting, and doing it while Gaza's post-ceasefire death toll climbs suggests Washington's practical position hasn't shifted from unconditional resupply — whatever the diplomatic language says. The beneficiaries are as much U.S. defense manufacturers as the Israeli government; the risk absorbed is entirely regional and entirely someone else's.

Al Jazeera · aljazeera.com/news/2026/9/16
NBC News · nbcnews.com/world/gaza/2026/09/16

West Bank: The Quiet Land-Seizure Escalation

Israel has stepped up land confiscation orders in the West Bank's Area A — nominally under Palestinian Authority civil control — issuing at least 15 seizure orders in the Jenin

backed Houthi forces seized Greater and Lesser Hanish islands, extending their grip on the Bab el-Mandeb chokepoint and striking Saudi oil infrastructure directly.

READ

Trump saying the war will end after votes are cast is either a genuine timeline or a message-discipline choice — either way, an incumbent party has an obvious incentive to want the costliest headlines (oil prices, casualties, a stalled economy) to resolve after, not before, an election. That incentive doesn't make the prediction false, but it should make you discount the confidence behind it.

Jerusalem Post · jpost.com/middle-east/article-909123

NPR · npr.org/2026/09/18/nx-s1-5973810

WORLD

France's Le Pen and Bardella Draw a Line on Russia

National Rally leaders Marine Le Pen and Jordan Bardella issued a joint statement Saturday warning Russia against trying to “dictate France's policy...through intimidation, threats, destabilization, or psychological pressure,” a day after President Macron briefed political leaders on plans to

RIGHT-OF-CENTER INSTITUTIONS

FIGURES

&

JD Vance

Beyond the “another chance” stumble (see U.S. Politics), Vance took the White House podium Thursday for the administration's first briefing in 42 days, defending the Venezuela oil deal and giving an Iran-war update, then warned that a premature U.S. exit from the region could trigger a “worldwide energy crisis” — an argument that cuts against war-weary voters in his own coalition even as it justifies staying the course.

The Hill · thehill.com/homenews/administration/6067935

Fox News · foxnews.com/live-news/iran-war-powers-vote-trump-strait-hormuz-saudi-strikes-09-16-26

Charlie Kirk

One year after his assassination, Turning Point USA unveiled an eight-foot statue of Kirk at its Phoenix headquarters; within a day, vandals spray-painted it and a memorial poster in red and tried to set the poster on fire. The vandalism briefly overshadowed the memorial itself, and TPUSA is separately reported to be using the anniversary moment to position itself ahead of the 2028 Republican presidential primary — a reminder that the organization's institutional ambitions outlived its founder.

AZFamily · azfamily.com/2026/09/14

CNN · cnn.com/2026/09/06/politics/charlie-kirk-turning-point-future-jd-vance

Rassemblement National (Le Pen / Bardella)

See World, above, on the Russia statement. Domestically, an appeals court this summer cut Le Pen's eligibility ban from five years to 45 months (30 suspended) while upholding her embezzlement conviction, clearing her to run in 2027; if she wins, Bardella is expected to be named prime minister. The Russia statement this week reads as

protect French infrastructure from Russian hybrid attacks and after Russia seized the assets of several French companies. It's a notable break from RN's historically Russia-accommodating instincts, and a sign that even Euroskeptic nationalist parties are being pulled toward confrontation with Moscow as election season approaches.

Meduza · meduza.io/en/news/2026/09/20

Ukrainska Pravda · pravda.com.ua/eng/news/2026/09/19

Oil Markets Feel the Houthi Escalation Directly

A month of sustained Houthi strikes on Saudi oil infrastructure and Red Sea shipping — now reinforced by the seizure of the Hanish islands — has reignited Yemen's civil war and given Iran added leverage in its standoff with Washington, since disrupting Saudi exports raises the cost of the war for the U.S. and its allies without Tehran striking a U.S. target directly. The IEA has called the broader Hormuz-linked disruption the largest supply shock in the history of the global oil market.

Bloomberg · bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-09-10

Washington Times · washingtontimes.com/news/2026/sep/14

positioning for that race — distancing RN from any perception of foreign alignment before her candidacy is formally underway.

Al Jazeera · aljazeera.com/news/2026/7/9

CDU/CSU (Friedrich Merz)

Chancellor Friedrich Merz called an emergency CDU executive committee meeting for the Sunday after two state elections, seeking assurance of continued party support after the AfD trounced the CDU by nearly 44-17 percent in Saxony-Anhalt and polled competitively in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern. Eight CDU state premiers and CSU leader Markus Söder have publicly backed Merz, but Söder's added line — that the government needs to “pick up the pace” — is a warning shot, not a full endorsement.

The Local · thelocal.de/20260915

Australian Tech Times · autechtimes.com/europe/csu-leaders-support-merz-as-german-chancellor

Reconquête (Éric Zemmour)

Zemmour confirmed this week he will run for the French presidency in 2027, hardening his line at Reconquête's summer conference to call for “remigration” of long-term unemployed immigrants, including those with legal status, declaring “no civilization has survived a change of people.” He is polling at roughly 2 percent, down sharply from his 7.07 percent first-round finish in 2022 — a reminder that rhetorical escalation and electoral strength are not moving in the same direction for him.

CNEWS · cnews.fr/france/2026-09-13

Franceinfo · franceinfo.fr/politique/eric-zemmour

Brandon Gill

The 32-year-old Texas congressman keeps consolidating his position as a rising MAGA figure: a high-profile speech at the GOP midterm convention in Dallas (with more speaking time than Senate candidate Ken Paxton), a new bid for the top Republican seat on the House Oversight Committee, a

\$1.1 million personal donation to the NRCC, and a lead role in a new ad attacking Texas Senate nominee James Talarico over transgender-care and China positions.

KERA News · keranews.org/politics/2026-09-10

Townhall · townhall.com/news/josephchalfant/2026/09/15

Tucker Carlson

Carlson drew renewed criticism this week for on-air comments alleging outsized Israeli influence in U.S. policy, and separately for effectively endorsing Democratic Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed in Michigan over Republican Mike Rogers, saying he “wouldn’t vote for Rogers at gunpoint.” The two positions — skepticism of Israel and a willingness to cross party lines against a pro-Israel Republican — are consistent with each other even if they scramble the usual right-of-center coalition lines.

Combat Antisemitism Movement · combatantisemitism.org/cam-news

Townhall · townhall.com/news/dmitri-bolt/2026/09/03

Benny Johnson

Johnson defended Texas GOP nominee Bo French’s controversial posts this week, saying “there’s nothing wrong with wanting Texas to stay Texas” and calling it “honorable to wish to preserve your own people” — language that drew immediate backlash for echoing explicitly racialized rhetoric rather than the civic-nationalist framing the mainstream movement usually prefers.

Joe.My.God. · joemygod.com/2026/09

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Iran and the New Rules of Global Power

Robert Pape’s new Foreign Affairs essay argues the Iran war is revealing a genuinely new pattern in great-power competition: China’s deliberate non-involvement is paying strategic dividends against Washington, while Russia is using the war instrumentally to advance its own goal of ending unipolar U.S. dominance, not because it has any stake in Iran itself. The piece is a useful corrective to reading every regional war as primarily about the region.

Robert Pape, Foreign Affairs (via author summary) · professorrobertpape.substack.com/p/today-foreign-affairs-published-my

ANGEL STUDIOS

Free to Watch This Week

Currently free on Angel (angel.com/category/free), no subscription required:

- **His Only Son** — a retelling of Abraham and Isaac’s journey to Mount Moriah.
- **The Wingfeather Saga** — animated fantasy series based on Andrew Peterson’s novels.
- **Tuttle Twins** — animated series introducing kids to free-market and civics concepts.

The Daily Wire

Coverage this week centered on the GOP midterm convention (Mary Margaret Olohan, Tim Rice, and Ben Domenech reporting from Dallas) and the mail-ballot ruling, framed as “Supreme Court Slams Brakes on Trump’s Mail-Ballot Plan” — a headline notably more critical of the administration than most conservative outlets ran this week.

Daily Wire · dailywire.com/election-hub

James Fishback

Less than a month after losing the Florida gubernatorial primary, Fishback returned to Florida Atlantic University for a “Town Hall on Our Future,” telling students “the race may be over, but our fight is just getting started” and blaming H-1B visas for a weak graduate job market — a sign he intends to stay a visible commentator rather than exit politics after the loss.

FAU University Press · upressonline.com/2026/09

Samuel Huntington

Huntington died in 2008, but his “Clash of Civilizations” thesis is being invoked constantly this year to explain the Iran war, including in a new essay arguing that the war shows less the truth of Huntington’s framework than “the continuing power of the ideas it set in motion” among policymakers who read events through exactly that lens. Worth remembering: Huntington’s own point was a warning about civilizational framing becoming self-fulfilling, not an endorsement of it.

World Politics Review · worldpoliticsreview.com/trump-us-iran-war-huntington-clash-civilizations

Where Has Conservatism Been, and Where Is It Going?

National Review’s September essay on the state of fusionism is a serious, non-cheerleading look at the coalition Frank Meyer built between libertarians and traditionalists during the Cold War, and why it has fractured under populism and personality politics. It engages seriously with the national-conservative critique — that fusionism’s economic libertarianism sold out the very communities traditionalism was meant to protect — without simply endorsing either faction, which is rarer than it should be in this debate.

National Review · nationalreview.com/2026/09/where-has-conservatism-been-and-where-is-it-going

- **A Week Away: The Series** — faith-and-family drama spinoff of the film.
- **Miracle** — recently added documentary/drama title.

Free titles rotate and are underwritten by Angel Guild members; availability can change without notice.

Angel Studios · angel.com/category/free

Coming to Theaters

- **Angel and the Badman** (Oct. 9) — Tommy Lee Jones and Zachary Levi in a reimagining of the John Wayne western.
- **Drummer Boy** (Nov. 6) — holiday-season family drama.
- **Hershey** (Thanksgiving) — biographical drama on chocolate magnate Milton Hershey.

MARKETS SNAPSHOT

AAPL (Apple Inc.) — \$252.29, +1.96% today. *Near 52-week highs, momentum intact; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 91%. Analyst avg. target upside: +34.51%.

LMT (Lockheed Martin Corp) — \$533.38, -0.88% today. *Lower half of 52-week range; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 38%. Analyst avg. target upside: +18.07%.

BLK (BlackRock Inc.) — \$1,069.78, +1.50% today. *Lower half of 52-week range; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 50%. Analyst avg. target upside: +24.91%.

XOM (Exxon Mobil Corp) — \$146.60, -2.67% today. *Upper half of 52-week range; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 58%. Analyst avg. target upside: +17.46%.

BTC-USD (Bitcoin) — \$81,442, +1.13% today. *Consolidating.*

XAU (Gold (spot)) — \$4,377.75, n/a today. *Watch for safe-haven bid.*

MARKET PREDICTIONS & MOVES

Insufficient data for a cross-asset read.

Informational market read compiled 2026-09-20, not personalized financial advice.

Figures via Google Finance and spot-gold web reporting, September 20, 2026. Defense and energy names remain the two sectors most exposed to Iran-war headline risk this cycle.